

# ROGUE SCREENCONNECT VBS EXECUTION

Defender XDR hunt for the source-observed  
ScreenConnect Windows client spawning  
Windows Script Host to execute numbered  
VBScript stages.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

SCREENCONNECT.WINDOWSCIENT.EXE

rogue remote access client



wscript.exe

1.vbs • 2.vbs • 3.vbs • 4.vbs

HUNT • TRIAGE • CONTAIN

verify authorized RMM context

REPORT DATE

6 September 2026

STATUS

Untested implementation sketch

PRIMARY TELEMETRY

Defender XDR /  
DeviceProcessEvents

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.4 / 10

Campaign-specific parent-child execution hunt. A match does not prove worm propagation or exploitation.



# EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision-grade summary and strict evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.4

Direct parent-child process telemetry captures an anomalous execution chain observed across unrelated organizations.

CLASSIFICATION

Campaign-specific execution

Hunting query - Untested implementation sketch. Exact filenames are mutable and legitimate ScreenConnect use must be separated.

- 3+organizations
- 4VBS stages
- 2observed dates
- 0thresholds

Source fact

Rogue ScreenConnect clients repeatedly spawned wscript.exe to execute 1.vbs through 4.vbs.

Vendor interpretation

Modified clients could transfer and run the same chain on newly connected ScreenConnect endpoints.

Assumptions

Defender for Endpoint retains full child command lines and the observed parent image name.

Evidence boundary

The process event does not prove malicious client modification, file transfer, successful staging, persistence, propagation or C2.



# THREAT MECHANICS

Observed chain and official vendor context.

BEHAVIOR

## 01 Social engineering

Victims were induced to deploy an unauthorized ScreenConnect client.  
→

## 02 Rogue RMM

The client established remote access in separate environments.  
→

## 03 Script launch

The Windows client spawned repeated wscript.exe children.  
→

## 04 Four stages

Numbered VBS files profiled, downloaded and decoded payload material.  
→

## 05 Persistence

A WindowsServiceHost User Run value pointed to AppData VBS.  
→

## 06 Propagation

Modified clients could queue script execution to new Host sessions.

| Date             | Direct observation                                                                  |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 20 August 2026   | Two incidents with rogue ScreenConnect and four VBS stages.                         |
| 24 August 2026   | Same anomalous chain after a refund-form social-engineering lure.                   |
| 3 September 2026 | Huntress update confirmed additional incidents.                                     |
| 3 September 2026 | ConnectWise disclosed affected guest file-transfer behavior and interim mitigation. |

### ATT&CK

T1059.005 Visual Basic and T1219.002 Remote Access Software are directly supported by the observed execution chain.



# TELEMETRY & EVIDENCE MODEL

Minimum data contract and observability gaps.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

**DeviceProcessEvents**

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint process creation with child image, command line and initiating image.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

DeviceFileEvents, DeviceRegistryEvents, DeviceNetworkEvents, signer information and ScreenConnect audit logs.

| Field                           | Reliability | Purpose                                        |
|---------------------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName | Documented  | Scope and pivots                               |
| FileName                        | Documented  | Child wscript.exe                              |
| ProcessCommandLine              | Documented  | Numbered VBS path token                        |
| InitiatingProcessFileName       | Documented  | ScreenConnect parent                           |
| InitiatingProcess*              | Documented  | Path, command line, account and remote session |
| ReportId                        | Documented  | Use with DeviceName and Timestamp              |

**Unavailable through this event**

Script content, ScreenConnect client modification, virtual file transfer, audit action, successful payload execution and worm-like propagation.

**Coverage failure**

No Defender for Endpoint, missing command line, renamed parent or child, later filename drift, or activity outside retention.



# HUNTING LOGIC

Three direct conditions with no aggregation or sequence.

KQL

HYPOTHESIS

If an attacker deploys the observed rogue ScreenConnect chain, process telemetry should show ScreenConnect.WindowsClient.exe creating wscript.exe with a path to one of the numbered VBScript stages. The behavior can be distinguished through authorized-instance inventory, parent path, signer, client configuration, script hashes and ScreenConnect audit evidence.

KQL - UNTESTED HUNT

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where FileName =~ "wscript.exe"
| where InitiatingProcessFileName =~ "ScreenConnect.WindowsClient.exe"
| where ProcessCommandLine contains @"\1.vbs"
  or ProcessCommandLine contains @"\2.vbs"
  or ProcessCommandLine contains @"\3.vbs"
  or ProcessCommandLine contains @"\4.vbs"
| project Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, ActionType,
  FileName, FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine,
  AccountDomain, AccountName, AccountUpn,
  InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessFolderPath,
  InitiatingProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessSHA1,
  InitiatingProcessAccountName,
  InitiatingProcessIntegrityLevel, InitiatingProcessTokenElevation,
  IsInitiatingProcessRemoteSession,
  InitiatingProcessRemoteSessionIP, ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

| THRESHOLD | WINDOW           | JOIN | KEY                | STATUS   |
|-----------|------------------|------|--------------------|----------|
| None      | Analyst-selected | None | Parent-child + VBS | Untested |



# TRIAGE & INVESTIGATION

Turn one process event into defensible RMM evidence.

WORKFLOW

1

## Validate lineage

Confirm exact parent, child, command line, account and timestamps.

2

## Verify authorization

Compare parent path, server URL, client ID, signer and owner with the RMM inventory.

3

## Collect scripts

Acquire numbered VBS files and compare hashes and content with the source.

4

## Review audit logs

Search for RunFiles or RanFiles from Process: Guest.

5

## Scope follow-on

Pivot to Run-key persistence, PowerShell, staged files, network activity and peer endpoints.

### Escalate

Unauthorized client, matching scripts, Guest execution, suspicious server, or source-observed persistence.

### Benign context

Approved technician action with a managed instance, ticket, trusted script and expected endpoint.

### Inconclusive

Historical event with missing client configuration, scripts or audit records.

## Response boundary

Do not reimage or attribute solely from the KQL match. Huntress recommends reimaging confirmed affected hosts after corroboration.



# FALSE POSITIVES & VALIDATION

Promotion gates for operational deployment.

QUALITY CONTROL

| SCENARIO                     | OVERLAP | DISPOSITION                                  |
|------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------------|
| Authorized technician script | M       | Verify ticket, instance, script and operator |
| Security simulation          | M       | Scope approved devices and window            |
| Unmanaged ScreenConnect      | H       | Escalate configuration and server review     |
| Matching Guest audit event   | H       | Contain and collect full chain               |

## Validation steps

1. Confirm full process command-line collection.
2. Run an authorized ScreenConnect-to-VBS test.
3. Verify parent and child fields against the process tree.
4. Baseline legitimate ScreenConnect script activity.

## Decision criteria

**Success:** controlled chain is visible and production matches are dispositionable.

**Rejection:** common legitimate technician workflows create inseparable overlap.

**Failure:** command lines or initiating process identity are unavailable.

### Tuning

Allowlist verified instance IDs, server URLs, deployment paths, signed binaries or managed device roles only after evidence. Do not suppress ScreenConnect globally.



# CONCLUSION & REFERENCES

Coverage statement, cross-platform limits and document control.

FINAL

## CONCLUSION

### A high-value execution hunt, not a generic ScreenConnect alert.

The parent-child chain is directly observed and Defender fields are documented. Filename drift and authorized RMM overlap block production classification until local validation.

## Cross-SIEM decision

**Splunk:** no reliable SPL without a verified EDR source, index, sourcetype and exact process/parent/command-line extractions.

**Chronicle:** no reliable YARA-L without a verified endpoint parser and exact UDM mapping for child, parent and command line.

## Deferred ideas

Generic ScreenConnect alerts, four-stage aggregation, IOC-only server rules, Run-key correlation, Guest audit-log correlation and PowerShell follow-on logic.

## References

1. Huntress, 3 Sep 2026 - Rogue ScreenConnect Installations Across Unrelated Hosts Suggest Worm-Like Activity.  
[huntress\[.\]com/blog/rogue-screenconnect-installations](#)
2. ConnectWise, 3 Sep 2026 - ScreenConnect Remote Access: Guest File Transfer Advisory.  
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3. Microsoft Learn - DeviceProcessEvents table.  
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## Document control

English dossier. No customer data. References defanged. HTML and rendering assets remain private and are excluded from publication.